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WEEKEND SPECIAL · CRYPTO UNCLE'S RESEARCH · 2026-09-20

Robinhood Chain / PONS: Riding the RWA Narrative, or Actually Onto Something?

Data as of 2026-09-19/09-20 unless noted; sourced inline, full list in section 14. The daily-line charts in sections 2, 6 and 11 are measured data (DefiLlama API + Robinhood Chain's own Blockscout, pulled 2026-09-20). This piece is mechanism analysis and data reporting only — **not investment advice**.

SUBJECTS
Robinhood Chain · PONS · Arc

DATA AS OF
2026-09-19 / 09-20

KEY DATE
09-29 gas subsidy expires

BYLINE
Uncle Product | @Uncle_Onchain

00 TL;DR

TVL (9/19)	CHAIN FEES	NETWORK GAS FEE	PONS SHARE PEAK
$980M	**−74%**	**−97%**	**29.6%**
new high every day since 7/1	$25.1M (9/4) → $6.6M (9/19)	$8M/day early Sept → $230K/day 9/16	of Solana+PONS meme volume, now 5.99% (9/19)

Call 1 **The July–August blowup on Robinhood Chain was real, but the engine was a "zero-cost mint-and-trade bot economy," not tokenized stocks themselves.** 91% of daily activity ran through a single launchpad, PONS, and the bulk of on-chain fee revenue came from meme minting and trading, full stop.

Call 2 **September 29 is the real dividing line.** The 90-day gas subsidy (counting from the July 1 mainnet launch) expires then; it covers transactions sent through the Robinhood Wallet. The 9/19 data already gives a preview of "what happens without the subsidy" — the network's own gas fee has crashed from a peak of $8M/day to $230K/day (−97%), while transaction count is down only 32%, meaning users haven't left, they're just spending far less per trade. But this is only the rehearsal **before** the subsidy is pulled; the real stress test comes **after**.

Call 3 **"Stock-paired meme" is an accounting trick that turns idle tokenized-stock inventory into trading volume, not a product innovation.** Traders actually do worse in this corner than in plain meme: true tokenized stocks show a 19.3% win rate on positions, versus 51.1% for ordinary meme coins. Stock-paired meme pools are a bad, forced fit — the RWA narrative needs an actual foothold, not a stock skin bolted onto a meme coin.

Call 4 **Arc's design — USDC as gas and as the pricing asset directly — is a genuine mechanical improvement**, closing off the "weekend float squeeze" exploit at the root. But Arc the chain itself probably can't capture the next wave — the mechanism is right, the vehicle isn't.

Call 5 **This is an era-specific narrative, unlikely to be replayed on the same vehicle.** What repeats is the playbook — "new chain + gas subsidy + launchpad" — not the same chain or the same winners. The signal worth watching is the first launchpad or chain to combine stablecoin pricing with a genuine retail distribution channel — nobody has that combination yet.

01 Background: Robinhood, Robinhood Chain, PONS

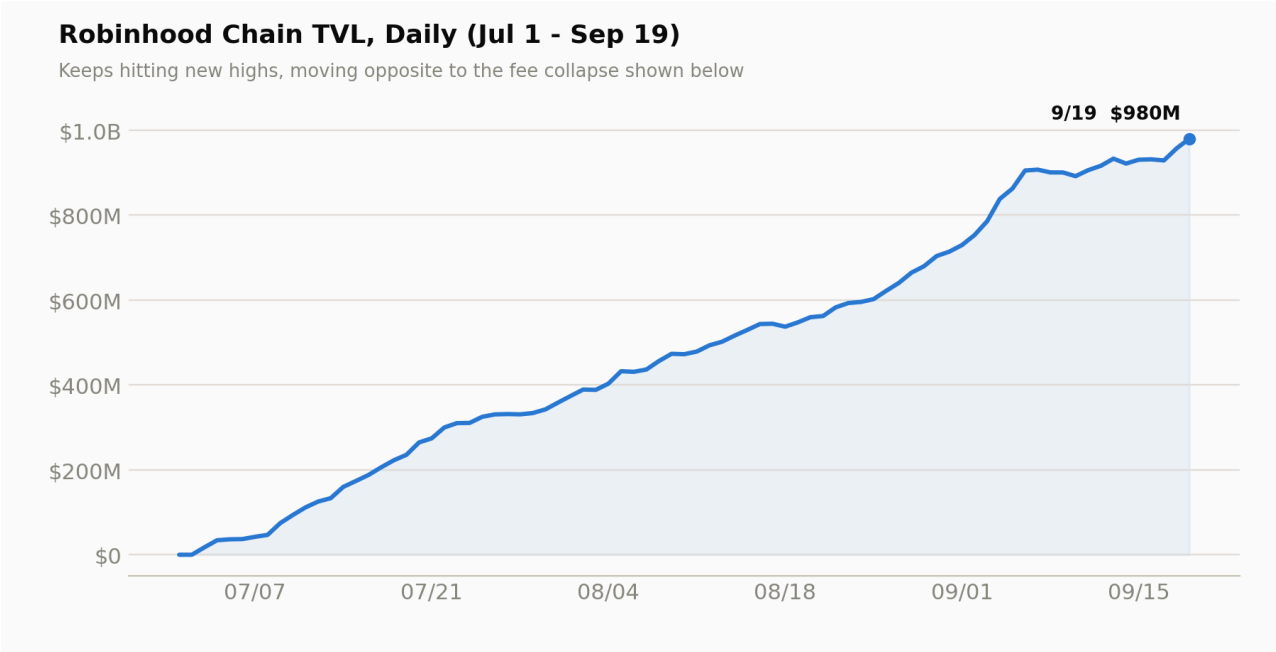
Robinhood Markets: founded 2013 by Vladimir Tenev and Baiju Bhatt (Stanford classmates who'd previously built high-frequency trading systems), listed on Nasdaq in July 2021 (HOOD) raising about $2.1B at an initial valuation near $32B, now an S&P 500 component. Its core product is commission-free stock/options/crypto trading aimed at young retail (average customer age 35), and it was the central platform in the 2021 "meme stock" retail-mania episode. Per its latest disclosure (FY2025 report, released 2026-02-10): over 27 million funded customers, $324B in Total Platform Assets (+68% YoY); FY2025 revenue of $4.473B (roughly $4.5B on the official headline number), net income of $1.883B, total balance-sheet assets of $38.1B. The company has visibly leaned into crypto over the last two years — acquiring Bitstamp, listing tokenized stocks/ETFs in the EU, expanding into wealth management and private banking, and pushing into Southeast Asia. (Sources: Wikipedia; Robinhood investor relations, 2026-02-10)

Robinhood Chain: an EVM L2 built on the Arbitrum Orbit (Nitro) stack, native Solidity/Vyper, ERC-4337, ETH as gas, currently run by a single Robinhood-operated sequencer (not yet decentralized — Robinhood controls block production), ~100ms block times, mainnet live July 1, 2026. It's built to host Robinhood's own tokenized stock/ETF trading plus a third-party launchpad ecosystem; graduated launchpad pools all land in Uniswap v3/v4. Zero SVM/Anchor code reuse, meaning any Solana team that wants to move over has to rewrite in Solidity + Uniswap v4 Hooks and get re-audited from scratch. (Sources: docs.robinhood.com/chain; Arbitrum blog)

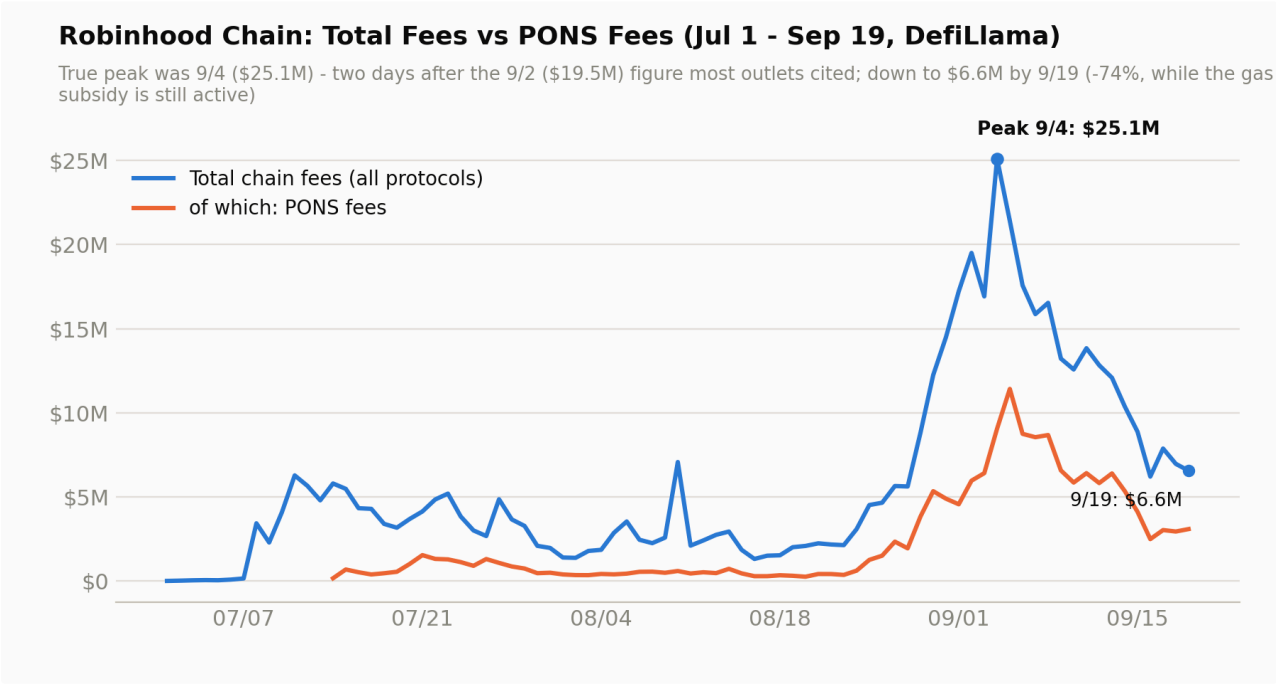
PONS: a launchpad on Robinhood Chain, running the same playbook as pump.fun — anyone mints a token, it trades along a bonding curve, and it graduates into a Uniswap pool once it clears a threshold. It became the dominant source of chain fees almost immediately after its late-July launch. On September 2, its single-day fees briefly hit $5.95M, ranking 4th across all of crypto; the same day it minted about 25,000 new tokens, for a cumulative 646,000 tokens and 167,000 creators. (Source: CoinDesk, 2026-09-03)

02 Robinhood Chain's heat curve: daily-line data, verified (7/1–9/19)

This version pulls a daily time series straight from DefiLlama/Blockscout (from the July 1 mainnet launch to now), replacing an earlier draft's news-clipping approach — scattered dates, inconsistent metrics. It's more reliable, and along the way it corrects a detail that most coverage got slightly wrong — see the correction box below.



TVL climbed from $0 on 7/1 to $980M on 9/19, with none of the pullback seen in fees — 9/19 is still the all-time high of the series. Source: DefiLlama historicalChainTvl.



The true peak for both chain fees and PONS fees was 9/4, not 9/2 as most coverage cites. Source: DefiLlama overview/fees.

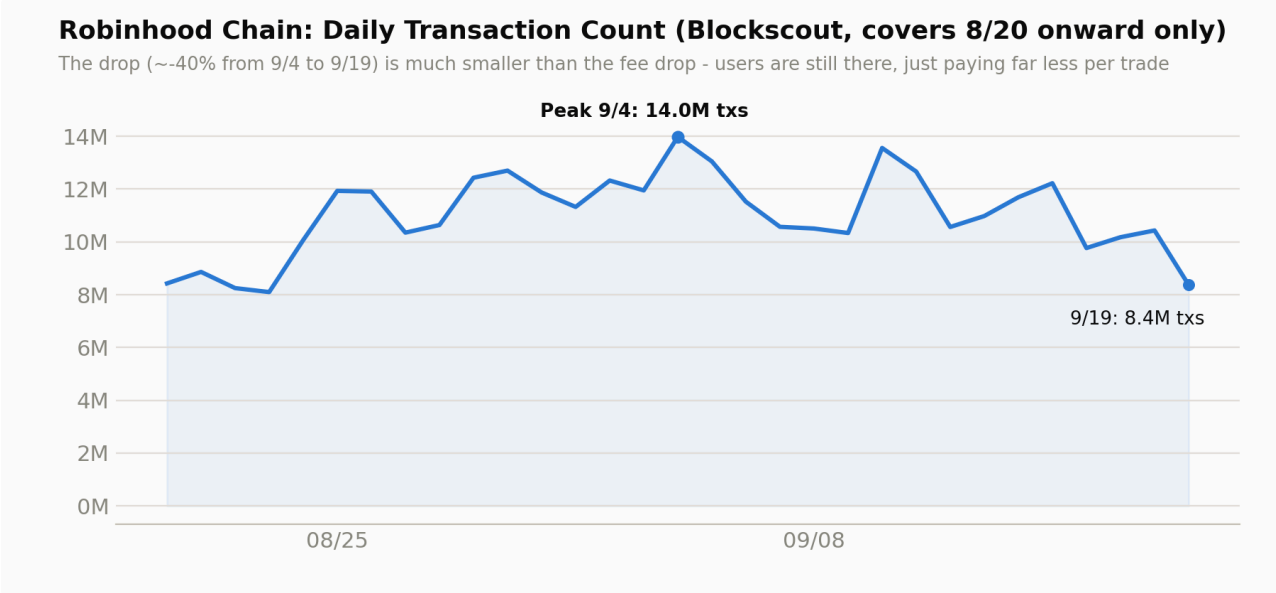
⚠ **Correction worth flagging** Most coverage (including an earlier draft of this piece) cites "September 2" as the fee peak. It isn't. DefiLlama's daily data puts the actual peak for both chain fees and PONS

fees on **September 4** — $25.1M and $9.05M respectively — clearly above the September 2 readings of $19.5M / $5.96M. The likely explanation: the September 2 figure was reported (by CoinDesk, published 9/3) while the day's numbers were still climbing and hadn't settled; the true peak two days later never got the same follow-up coverage, so "9/2 was the peak" stuck as the widely-cited version even though it isn't the most accurate one.

The lesson: any claim about "when the peak happened" should be checked against the full, revisitable on-chain daily series — not the first headline that used a date.

After the peak, chain fees fell from $25.1M on 9/4 to $6.6M on 9/19, a drop of about **74%**. That's a different number from CoinDesk's narrower metric — the "network gas fee" generated specifically by Robinhood Wallet transactions. CoinDesk's own 09-19 piece actually gives two versions of this: a single-day peak comparison of roughly **$8M/day (early September) → $230K/day on 9/16 (−97%)**, and a 7-day-average comparison of **$4M/day (week of 9/04) → $641K/day (week of 9/16) (−82%)**. Both are correct; they're just different measurement windows, not a contradiction. DefiLlama's "chain fees" sum up every protocol's fees on the chain (including app-level fees like PONS's), while CoinDesk's "gas fee" is strictly the raw network transfer cost — different metrics, not interchangeable, but pointing the same direction: both are collapsing, and both of these collapses happened while the subsidy was still active.

- The same CoinDesk piece has a useful current-state snapshot backing up the "users haven't left" read: in the 24 hours through 9/19, apps built on the chain (mainly PONS and similar launchpads) still collected about $8M in fees and kept $1.5M of it as revenue, while the network's own gas take was only $230K. App-layer revenue dwarfs network-layer revenue — the same phenomenon as "users are still here, they're just spending far less per transaction," seen from a different angle. (Source: CoinDesk, 2026-09-19, "Robinhood Chain fees collapse 97% even as transactions stay near record highs")



Blockscout's API only covers the trailing 30 days, so 7/1–8/19 can't be reconstructed. Transaction count also peaked on 9/4 (14.0M), falling to 8.37M by 9/19 — about −40%, far smaller than the −74% fee decline. That gap is the clearest evidence users stuck around while their per-trade spend collapsed: this looks like natural cooling, not an exodus.

◇ **Data that couldn't be filled in** (stated plainly, no invented numbers): daily active addresses on Robinhood Chain, and daily mint/graduation counts for PONS, have no public time-series API we could find — only isolated news snapshots (e.g. 7/27: 12,384 new Pons tokens in a day, 73% of all new chain tokens; 8/31: 17,909 new Pons tokens; 9/1: Pons volume of $370.2M, 59% of all launchpad volume on the chain) that can't be strung into a continuous series.

The real stress test hasn't happened yet. Every decline above occurred while the subsidy was still in effect. Once it expires on 9/29 and every transaction carries a real gas cost on top, that's an additional real-cost shock layered on top of activity that's already cooled.

03 TVL really is rising — but its composition has nothing to do with meme

Daily TVL series (DefiLlama historicalChainTvl): 07-25 $325M → 08-31 $714M → 09-04 $838M → 09-07 $907M → 09-17 $929M → 09-19 $980M. TVL is up another 17% since the 09-04 fee peak.

Meanwhile every meme metric in the same window moved the other way: Pons daily fees fell from $9.05M (9/4) to $3.08M (9/19), −66% (DefiLlama, measured); the 7-day average network gas fee (CoinDesk's narrower metric, distinct from DefiLlama's chain-fee aggregate) fell from $4M/day

(week of 9/04) to $641K/day (week of 9/16), −82% (see section 2 for the source); PONS's burn-adjusted market cap fell from $636M (9/5) to $477M (9/17), −25%.

COMPONENT	AMOUNT	SHARE	NATURE
Morpho Blue	$544M	55%	Includes $456M+ in the Steakhouse USDG vault — the backend for **Robinhood Earn**, US-compliant retail stablecoin yield ("up to 7% APY"), borrowed against by market makers/liquidity providers
Uniswap	$281M	29%	Stock-token pools plus permanently-locked v4 pools left behind by graduated Pons tokens
Lighter	$92M	9%	Perpetuals protocol
Fables / Arcus / Spark	$67M	7%	Other protocols
Launchpad-related (Noxa, etc.)	$5.2M	<1%	**The only TVL directly tied to meme trading**

> ◆ **Bottom line**: the "capital that's staying" is overwhelmingly US retail stablecoin deposits (Robinhood Earn) plus institutional market-making credit plus LP value structurally locked by Pons graduations — not capital that can rotate into meme. Robinhood Earn (US-compliant users) and Wallet-based meme trading (ex-US users) are essentially two disjoint user bases. Rising TVL doesn't rebut the meme cooldown.

04 The "Robinhood brings its own users" myth

- Trading from Robinhood's own app accounts for roughly 1–2% of daily on-chain transactions at peak; the rest comes through crypto-native rails — GMGN/Axiom/pump.fun front-ends, Uniswap, launchpads. (CoinDesk Research, 2026-09-04)
- Robinhood Wallet is an ex-US product; Lighter perpetuals block users in the US/UK/Canada/Switzerland/UAE/Singapore.
- No dApp store, no standing grant program (just a $1M Arbitrum Open House prize); third parties only get in through bilateral deals (Lighter, Morpho, Uniswap, Paxos).

- User quality genuinely looks more "human" — lower bot share: 2.1M wallets active on Robinhood over 30 days vs. 10.2M on Solana; median wallet volume $189 vs. $7; top 1% of wallets account for 62% of volume vs. 97.5% on Solana; bots (>10,000 transactions) drive 16% of volume vs. 83%. (Bitquery, 2026-09-03)
- But a separate, more granular Bitquery study (63.5M transactions / 824,000 wallets, 2026-07-16 to 07-28) found extreme concentration too: **a single address accounted for 25.0% of all chain transactions, the top five for 70.2%**; about 84% of daily-minted tokens (roughly 15,000/day) never trade again after launch.

05 The track record of "porting a launchpad to a new chain": nobody has ever cleared 20% of the home chain

LAUNCHPAD	HOME → NEW CHAIN	OUTCOME	SOURCE
Bags	Solana→Robinhood (beta 07-11)	Solana still ~91%, Robinhood ≈9% (after ~7 weeks)	Meme Central; HokaNews
Flap	BSC→Robinhood/X Layer/Monad	BSC keeps 95% of fees; the three new chains combined ≈5%	TechFlow, 2026-09-18
Pools.trade	Native to Robinhood, launched 08-05 (Uniswap Labs' own)	~50% share on day one → by 08-31, daily fees of $38.6K vs. Pons's $4.89M (<1%)	The Defiant, 2026-09-01
Noxa / Pons / Long	Native to Robinhood, first cohort	Every winner is native-plus-early; Noxa paused 07-11 after wash-mint abuse, Pons took over	CoinGecko, 2026-07-29
pump.fun	Solana→ETH/Base/BNB/Robinhood	**Never actually ported the minting contract** — only cross-chain trading, via acquisitions of Padre (Oct '25) and Vyper (Feb '26); took 7 months to ship EVM trading	The Block, 2026-02-05; Crypto Briefing, 2026-05-26

LAUNCHPAD	HOME → NEW CHAIN	OUTCOME	SOURCE
Virtals	Base→Solana	The Solana side stayed small ($17.3M market cap, $210K daily volume)	Solana Compass

Takeaway: this isn't just a "Robinhood Chain" pattern — it's an industry-wide one. The winner is always native-plus-early, without exception. That rule is exactly what drives the "will it repeat" judgment in section 13.

06 Rewriting "EVM chains can't do meme"

The accurate version is "high-gas EVM chains with no retail distribution can't do meme" — not the EVM stack itself. Robinhood Chain is an EVM chain, so is BSC, and the two of them combined now out-trade every meme venue except Solana in a given week. It's worth separating three layers here.

Layer 1: on pure technical comparison, Monad is the counterexample

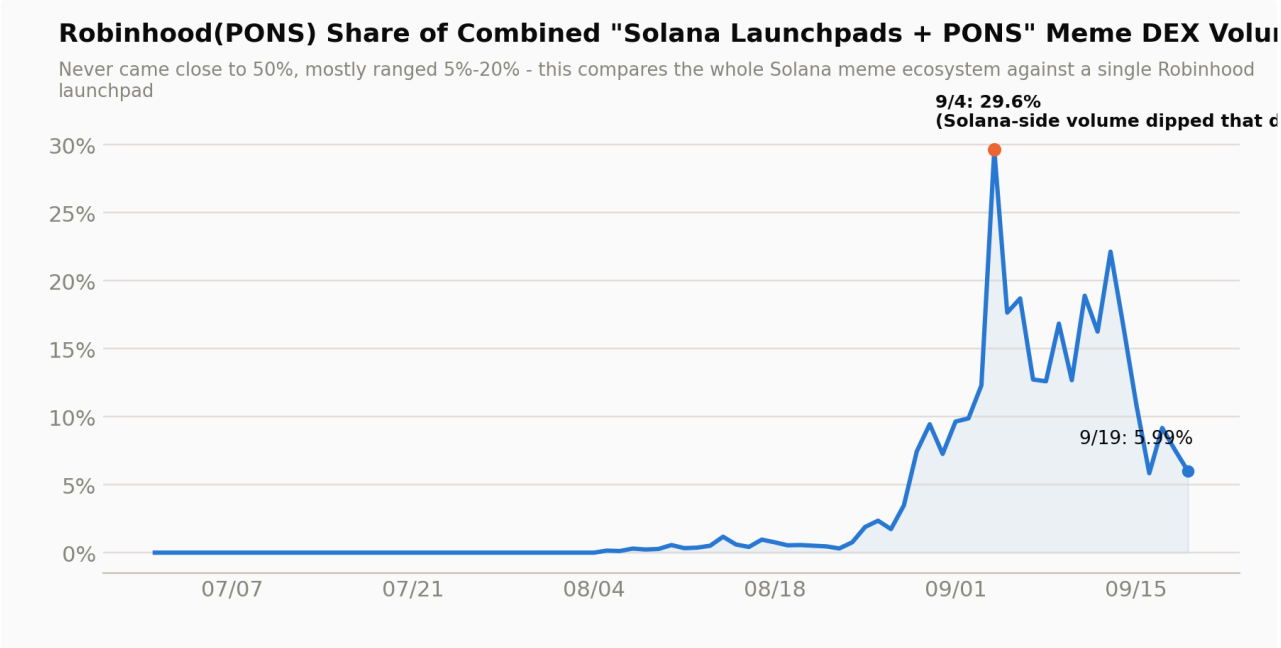
Monad is a parallelized, EVM-compatible L1 purpose-built for high-frequency use cases, advertising "10,000 TPS, near-zero fees" at mainnet; its native launchpad, nad.fun, was explicitly built to clone pump.fun. That alone disproves the claim that "EVM chains can't build low-gas, high-frequency meme infrastructure" — technically, it's entirely doable.

Layer 2: doing it technically doesn't mean capturing share

nad.fun's actual numbers (DefiLlama): 30-day fees of just $142,474, 30-day protocol revenue of $59,312, 30-day DEX volume of $6.54M, TVL of only $480K — ranked 17th by TVL among launchpad protocols, and down another 17% week-over-week. By comparison, pump.fun alone posts $44.66M in 30-day fees — more than 300x nad.fun; even Bags, an already-fading Solana launchpad ($1.75M in 30-day fees), is still 12x nad.fun. Low gas alone didn't translate into volume, which tells you the deciding factor in this category isn't a technical spec (TPS, gas cost) — it's retail distribution, community trust, and tolerance for a bot-driven economy. That echoes sections 4 and 5: Robinhood Chain won because it has the Robinhood App/Wallet as a distribution channel; Monad, technically superior, didn't manage to replicate that outcome.

Layer 3: what's genuinely disproven is high-gas or strategically-wavering EVM environments — think Ethereum mainnet and Base

- Weekly meme volume through 08-26: Solana $5.20B (85%), BSC $412M, Robinhood $389M, Ethereum $83M (0.9%), Base $31M (0.5%). (SolanaFloor, 2026-08-26)
- Base's content-coin push was declared a failure by Armstrong: "It didn't work. We pivoted earlier this year." ZORA is down 95%. (The Defiant, 2026-07-13)
- Solana minted a record 263,151 tokens in a single day on 09-10. (CoinReporter, 2026-09-11)



Daily DEX volume of Solana's main launchpads (pump.fun + PumpSwap + LaunchLab + StonkFun) summed against PONS on Robinhood. Source: DefiLlama.

Robinhood/PONS's share **never got close to, let alone above, 50%** across the whole window. The highest single day was 29.6% on 9/4 — and that was because Solana-side volume happened to crater to $366M that day, shrinking the denominator, not because PONS itself surged. Most of the time it sat in a 5%–20% band, and by 9/19 it was back down to 5.99%. The reason is simple: PumpSwap alone (the secondary market for graduated pump.fun tokens) routinely does $600M–800M a day — an order of magnitude bigger than all of PONS combined. This is fundamentally "an entire Solana meme ecosystem vs. a single Robinhood launchpad," not two evenly matched rivals slugging it out.

> ⚠ **A mix-up worth untangling** A separate claim ("from 09-08, native Solana volume inside the pump.fun app overtook Robinhood-related tokens again," cited via KuCoin/Binance Square/Geo News, 2026-09-09) is actually about a **much narrower slice** — not "the whole Solana ecosystem vs. all of Robinhood Chain," but the split **inside the pump.fun mobile app itself** between its

"native Solana token" volume and its "Robinhood-linked token" volume: after September 1, Robinhood-linked tokens outpaced native Solana tokens inside the app, until Solana native retook the lead on September 8. DefiLlama only publishes pump.fun's total app volume, not this internal split, so verifying it independently would need a paid on-chain tagging service — this piece hasn't done that. **Don't conflate this app-internal source-switch with the ecosystem-wide PONS-share chart above** — they're different granularities and can easily point in different directions.

- 30-day (08-09~09-07) launchpad **protocol revenue** share: pump.fun 64.20%, Pons 28.21%, StonkFun 7.58%. (CoinGecko, 2026-09-08)
- 30-day **gross fees**: Pons $132.9M vs. pump.fun $44.7M (≈3x); **retained protocol revenue**: Pons $23.5M vs. pump.fun $34.2M — pump.fun keeps more, meaning Pons hands a larger share of its fee take to creators/holders and retains proportionally less. (DefiLlama, 2026-09-19)

- **Corrected framing**: it isn't that "EVM is inherently bad at meme" — it's that "low gas is just the entry ticket; without retail distribution and tolerance for a bot economy, technical superiority doesn't matter." The same framework applies to section 11's judgment on Arc (a better USDC-pricing mechanism, still missing retail distribution) — it's the consistent lens this whole report uses.

07 The September 29 gas-subsidy expiry, in full

Subsidy window	2026-07-01 (mainnet launch) to 2026-09-29, 90 days
Who it covers	Transactions sent through the Robinhood Wallet; Robinhood reimburses the ETH gas cost
After expiry	All transactions revert to paying normal ETH gas, no reimbursement
Mid-window detail	Robinhood had already lowered the subsidy threshold to $0.5 (per KuCoin), signaling it was already actively narrowing the subsidy ahead of the deadline

Why this is a hard metric	PONS's high-frequency trial-and-error model depends on "mint 20 tokens to land 1 winner" at near-zero cost per attempt. Once the subsidy is gone, every mint/swap costs real money again, and the marginal cost of "spray and pray" rises sharply
The pre-expiry rehearsal	9/16 single-day **network gas fee** was $230K (not chain fees — those were $6.6M on 9/19, see section 2), down 97% from the early-September single-day peak of $8M; on a 7-day-average basis it's $4M (week of 09-04) → $641K (week of 09-16), −82%. Both percentages come from the same 09-19 CoinDesk piece using two different measurement windows — not a contradiction. Separately, Pons's weekly trading volume fell 37% week-over-week, and its protocol revenue fell from $10.7M to $5.8M — all of this while the **subsidy was still active**
A misread worth flagging	Don't mistake "the natural cooldown while the subsidy is still active" for "the answer to what happens after the subsidy is gone" — the latter hasn't happened yet

- **Independent corroboration**: a separate 2026-09-11 industry study (Binance Alpha's long-run review of 495 MEME projects) also flags "Robinhood Chain's gas subsidy expiring 2026-09-29" as the next structural checkpoint — the same conclusion as this report, arrived at independently, which suggests it's an industry-consensus observation rather than a one-off view.

08 Solana's launchpad landscape, as PONS's benchmark

30-day fees, DefiLlama, 2026-09-19:

PLATFORM	30D FEES	30D PROTOCOL REVENUE	STATUS
pump.fun + PumpSwap	$44.66M	$34.18M	$1.227B cumulative; Q3 already exceeds Q2
StonkFun (launched 08-03)	$13.07M	$13.07M	#2 on Solana; hit $1.5M in a single day on 09-06, briefly topping pump.fun
Raydium LaunchLab / BONK.fun	$3.6M / $3.5M	$0.7M / $2.1M	Bonk Inc. took home $3.92M in H1

PLATFORM	30D FEES	30D PROTOCOL REVENUE	STATUS
Bags	$1.75M	$0.87M	Once had 33.5% share in January; now down to $3.5K in daily fees
Graphite (LiveBONK)	$1.4M	$1.2M	—
Jupiter Studio	$86K	$78K	Marginal
Believe / Heaven / Boop / Time.fun	≈0	≈0	Effectively dead (Believe's founder arrested 04-22; Heaven's 100%-buyback model went to zero)

For scale: pump.fun's 30-day fees alone ($44.66M) are already roughly 10x Pons's single-day peak. That says Pons's current "#4 across all of crypto" is closer to a **spike** than a demonstration of **steady-state revenue power** — another data point for the "era-specific narrative" read.

09 Structural pain points across the launchpad category (PONS's environment)

- **Graduation rate**: about 1-in-16 (6.25%) for Pons vs. about 1-in-9 (11%) for pump.fun (measured 2026-08-04 to 09-02, Bitquery, same methodology for both). Part of the gap is age — Pons only launched 08-12 and its tokens are simply younger; Solana's bonding curves have had two years to build up the bot infrastructure that pushes tokens over the graduation line, and Pons hasn't caught up yet.
- **Graduation is a cliff**: 73% of tokens crash within 20 minutes of migrating; 60.26% fall more than 20% below their migration price. (arXiv 2602.13480, 2026-02-13)
- **Bundling and insiders**: 28.13% of holders are bundled accounts controlling 36.50% of supply; 21.4% of pre-migration trades are wash trades. (same source)
- **Rug rate**: 98.6% are pump-and-dumps (Solidus Labs); >80% rug within an hour. (arXiv 2608.20271, 2026-08-20)
- **Retention collapse**: only 3% of users have ever made more than $1,000. (Solana Compass, 2026-06-10)

These are chronic, category-wide launchpad problems. PONS hasn't solved a single one — it's just re-running the same show on a louder stage.

10 Stock-paired meme: the mechanism, three cases, and a data rebuttal

10.1 The mechanism, precisely

Stock tokens (NVDAx, an on-chain HIMS wrapper, etc.) function here as the **pricing asset for a meme trading pair**, not decoration. The path: to buy a given meme, you first swap into its paired stock token — the pool is `MEMETOKEN/stock-token`, not `MEMETOKEN/USDC`; every trade's fee is denominated in the stock token and split among creators, holders, and platform buybacks. A meme's "dollar price" is literally "its exchange rate against the stock token" times "the stock token's dollar price at that moment" — so the meme inherits the stock's beta by construction, not because anyone deliberately wanted the meme to ride the stock's hype. It's a mechanical consequence of the pricing-asset choice.

10.2 The real driver isn't traders — it's how the chain and issuers book the trades

What actually drove this playbook's volume: **every meme trade on the chain gets booked as a "tokenized-stock trade."** Both Robinhood Chain and BSC use this accounting convention. The result: Solana's share of "tokenized-stock spot volume" fell from 71% to 30% within two weeks (through August 27) (Crypto Briefing, 2026-09-07) — not because Solana's actual tokenized-stock business shrank, but because Robinhood Chain and BSC were counting huge volumes of meme trading under that label, manufacturing the illusion that "tokenized stocks are exploding." BNB Chain went further, putting up a $4 million reward pool to get platforms like four.meme running "4Stock" pairings.

10.3 Case one: the BONER/HIMS weekend float squeeze (Aug 30–Sept 1)

TIMESTAMP	PRICE / STATE	PREMIUM
Friday NYSE close	$28.84 (baseline)	–
Sunday 21:46 UTC	Ramp begins	+3.1%
Sunday 23:36 UTC (peak)	$61.15	**+112.0%**

TIMESTAMP	PRICE / STATE	PREMIUM
Monday 00:47 UTC (second spike)	$55.61	+92.8%
Monday 00:43:30 UTC	Issuer resumes minting, 1,000 tokens/batch, 294 consecutive batches	–
Monday 01:59 UTC (convergence)	$29.31	+1.6%

Position concentration: on Sunday night, of 15,227 HIMS tokens in circulation, about 13,100 (86%) were locked inside the BONER/HIMS pool, leaving only 92 in the main HIMS/USDG stablecoin pool — nearly the entire float had been routed into pricing a meme coin instead of sitting in a normal trading pool.

Why it worked: any wrapped asset whose supply-issuance rules follow real-world market hours becomes a closed-end-fund-style dislocation the moment a weekend closes trading. Three conditions have to line up: ① a small on-chain float (15,227 tokens, roughly $440K — a rounding error against Hims & Hers's actual 225 million real-world shares); ② a liquidity pool deliberately paired directly against the stock token rather than a stablecoin, so every dollar of buy pressure mechanically becomes buy pressure on the stock token; ③ a closed window where supply can't expand (Friday 21:21 UTC close to Monday 00:00 UTC open).

Who won, who lost: the real Hims & Hers stock never moved and not a single real share changed hands. Winners were BONER holders (the token ran from about $0.0024 to $0.0147, better than 6x) and the issuer (who minted new tokens at NAV and sold them at a premium once trading resumed Monday). Losers were retail buyers who bought in the $40–55 range over the weekend thinking they were getting discounted stock exposure. **This isn't a black swan — it's a repeatable, premeditated manipulation.** Line up "small float + directly-paired pool + weekend window" again, and it plays out the same way.

10.4 Case two: pump.fun got pulled from the App Store for copying this playbook (Sept 10–11)

On September 10, pump.fun shipped a "Custom Pairs" feature supporting 93 pricing assets, including 20 US stocks. On the evening of September 11 (US Eastern time), Apple pulled the pump.fun app from the US and India App Stores with no official statement — the store simply shows "this app is not available in your country or region." It stayed available on Canadian iOS and on Android (Google Play, over 500,000 downloads). PUMP's token fell 12% within 24 hours, dropping below its ICO price and 58% off its all-time high. Apple never confirmed a link between

the removal and the stock-pairing feature, but the timing alone is a strong enough correlation that anyone thinking of copying the playbook should think twice — it sits right at the edge of platform risk.

10.5 Case three: AMC's CEO goes public, regulatory friction escalates (early September)

AMC's CEO Adam Aron, in his own words: "We have no connection to this at all, and do not condone it in any way" — calling it "contemptible" and "outrageous," and saying AMC is already consulting securities lawyers about legal options. The core dispute: Robinhood tokenized AMC stock without AMC's consent, and retail buyers may not understand the legal gap between "an on-chain tokenized stock" and "a synthetic exposure held indirectly through an SPV" (Robinhood's own explanation for a prior, similar dispute with OpenAI) — buyers think they hold indirect equity; what they may actually hold is a settlement contract. OpenAI had previously and publicly denied that Robinhood's tokens represent real equity in it. This category of dispute has been called stock trading's "Napster moment" (Fortune, 2026-09-14), hinting it may be the opening act of a broader wave of licensing disputes. Robinhood has not directly responded to AMC's allegation.

10.6 The data rebuttal to "stock-pairing makes meme safer or more legitimate"

Bitquery's full-dataset analysis (trading_rt) of July 16–28, 2026 — 63.5M transactions, 824,000 wallets:

ASSET CLASS	SHARE OF PROFITABLE POSITIONS	MEDIAN RETURN
True tokenized stocks	**19.3%**	-4.7%
Ordinary meme coins	**51.1%**	-27.7%
Fake tokens impersonating listed tickers	very low	**-52.4% (n=64,000 wallets)**

- The "mild-looking" −4.7% median loss on true tokenized stocks doesn't reflect a "safer" asset — it mostly reflects the fact that most holders never even got to experience real price swings before platform spreads and thin liquidity quietly ground their capital down.
- Price discovery itself is broken: a tokenized GameStop share traded between $59.17 and $246.72 across different pools on the same day, taking 48 hours and eight liquidity pools to converge near $21.40.
- Per a broader figure disclosed by Bubblemaps/Bitget, **roughly six in ten** (63%) Robinhood Chain traders are underwater; different sources put the specific figure between 62% and 63%,

a gap likely explained by measurement window or sample differences rather than any real disagreement about "most people here are losing money."

> - **Bottom line**: stock-pairing doesn't add a layer of insurance to meme coins — it stacks a new set of risks (a thinly-liquid wrapper, broken price discovery, supply rules disconnected from the real market) on top of meme's existing volatility. It looks more "sophisticated," but it's actually a riskier, more regulator-sensitive version of meme. It's a bad, forced fit; the RWA narrative needs an actual foothold, not a stock skin on a meme coin.

11 Arc: is USDC-as-gas/USDC-as-pricing-asset the more sensible direction?

11.1 The mechanism

Circle's Arc (mainnet 2026-09-16) is an EVM chain with USDC as gas, run at genesis by 11 permissioned validators (BlackRock, DTCC, Visa, Mastercard, and others), planning a move to PoS in 2027. Its core design is a "single-asset model": the USDC a user bridges in is both the asset they hold and the token they spend on fees, targeting a base fee near $0.01 per transaction — a contrast to the usual two-asset EVM model (holding both ETH and a trading token). Trading pairs are priced directly in USDC, sidestepping the complexity of an ETH-USDC secondary pair. (Note: Arc standardizes USDC into two decimal representations — 18 decimals as the native gas asset, 6 as an ERC-20 — which causes a cosmetic bug where wallets can display balances a trillion times too large; that's an implementation detail, not something that changes the core mechanism.)

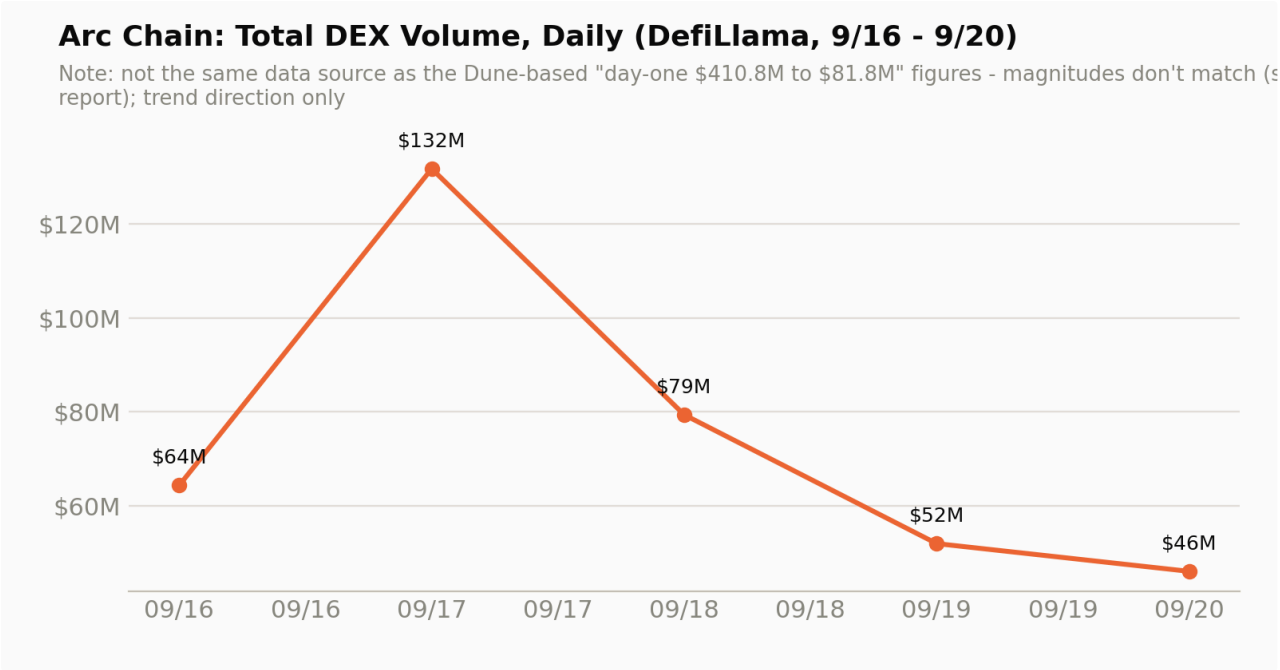
11.2 Is a USDC pool actually the more sensible next-round bet?

This splits into two separate judgments. USDC pricing genuinely is a sturdier mechanism than stock-pairing — USDC is a deep, liquid asset Circle can mint or redeem on demand 24/7, so there's no structural gap where "supply can't expand over the weekend, a small pool gets squeezed off its peg." It closes off the BONER/HIMS playbook at the mechanism level. But Arc the chain itself probably can't capture the next wave: its validators are 11 reputationally-cautious, permissioned institutions — Visa, Mastercard, BlackRock among them — with no retail distribution channel, and its first-day launchpad volume had already fallen 80% by 9/19. **The mechanism is right; the vehicle isn't** — what's actually worth tracking is the first launchpad or chain to combine "stablecoin pricing" with "a real retail distribution channel." Nobody has that combination yet.

11.3 The data behind this call — and a genuine data-source conflict, disclosed honestly

The news/Dune version (the first-reported figures, not independently verifiable day-by-day): on Arc's first day (09-16) — 7.76M transactions, $410.8M in DEX volume, 97,025 tokens minted, with launchpads accounting for **82%** of DEX volume ($336.3M; a single launchpad, Arguspad, took $202.35M of that — roughly half — followed by Minara.fun at $36.41M, Tollylabs at $19.65M, and RadarDEX at $13.11M). By 09-19, 24h DEX volume had fallen to $81.8M (−80% from day one), TVL sat at $341.7M, and the largest launchpad, Tolly, was down to just $1,949 in 24h fees. (Cryptopolitan, 2026-09-17; Dune dashboard by adam_tehc, via BeInCrypto/CryptoNews.net)

> ⚠ **What checking this turned up** DefiLlama is badly undercounting Arc's launchpad activity — the "82% / $410M → $81.8M" figures above come from Dune, not DefiLlama, and the two don't reconcile. DefiLlama's `overview/dexs/Arc` only individually tracks nine launchpads (Wonk Fun, SolonPad, Tolly, Peach Launchpad, ARK Launch, RadarDEX, and a few others), and their combined single-day volume never exceeds 1.3% of total chain DEX volume — two orders of magnitude off the 82% figure. The likely cause: the two biggest first-day launchpads, Arguspad and Minara.fun, don't appear in DefiLlama's protocol list at all, probably because their swaps route through underlying Uniswap V3/V4 pools, so the volume gets attributed to Uniswap rather than to the launchpad itself — a difference in protocol-level attribution architecture. PONS and pump.fun, by contrast, run their own bonding-curve contracts, so their volume attributes cleanly to themselves; it's a different architecture entirely.



Note: this does not match the Dune-sourced "first day $410.8M to $81.8M" figure above — different data source, different order of magnitude. This chart is directional only, not a measure of true scale. Source: DefiLlama overview/dexs/Arc.

DefiLlama's own recorded chain-wide DEX volume fell from $131.6M on 09-17 to $46.2M on 09-20, about −65% — the direction matches the "cliff-drop" narrative, but neither the absolute numbers nor the 82% launchpad-share figure reconcile with Dune's. Filling in the missing middle days (09-17, 09-18) of the "$410M→$81.8M" curve isn't possible with any free public API right now — it would require a paid Dune account, or the analyst publishing the underlying dashboard link. That gap is itself a finding: Arc's own data infrastructure hasn't caught up yet — even the basic question of "how hot is this chain, really" can't get a consistent free-tool answer, which further supports the 11.2 read that Arc lacks retail distribution and has struggled on execution.

Why it cooled so fast — KuCoin's two explanations: ① execution missteps — an official product manager posted a meme of CEO Jeremy Allaire's dog branded as Arc with the caption "The Duke of Arc has arrived," a bluntly promotional style that turned retail off, and an official livestream that damaged community trust through appearance-mocking banter rather than building it; ② severe launchpad oversaturation — more than 50 launchpads piled in before launch, fragmenting liquidity, with every platform trying to claim it was the leader and every community trying to pump its own token, leaving retail with no consensus on which platform to use and capital unable to concentrate anywhere.

Structural disadvantages (per a separate KuCoin analysis): its validator set — Visa, Mastercard, BlackRock, DTCC, Circle itself, and other regulated institutions — carries a built-in reputational aversion to "on-chain speculative mania"; its user entry point runs through card networks and

asset managers rather than a Robinhood-App-style direct line to retail; and its economic design has no native token, no buyback mechanism, USDC-denominated gas, and a **closed public mempool** — that last point matters most, since it shuts down the bot-driven, front-running economy that powers Robinhood Chain, leaving bots with no edge to exploit on Arc.

11.4 Arc vs. Robinhood Chain

DIMENSION	ROBINHOOD CHAIN	ARC
Pricing-asset design	Stock tokens (weekend supply-gap exploit)	USDC (no supply gap, mintable 24/7)
Retail distribution	**Yes (Robinhood App/Wallet)**	**No (institutional/card-network channels)**
Validator makeup	Single Robinhood-run sequencer	11 regulated institutions, jointly validating
Mempool	**Public — bots can front-run**	**Closed — no edge for bots**
First-week heat	**Exploded, sustained for weeks**	**Exploded, then fell 80% within days**
Stance on meme	Tolerated / enabled — it's the main revenue driver	No stated stance; execution has been the actual drag

- **Bottom line**: right now Arc has the better mechanism (USDC pricing) but no retail entry point; Robinhood Chain has the retail entry point but a flawed pricing mechanism (stock tokens). Nobody currently has both. Whoever combines them first is a strong candidate to be the next PONS-scale breakout — the single most concrete, trackable signal this report can offer for the next round.

12 Myth-busting table

THE CLAIM	WHY IT'S MISLEADING	WHAT'S ACTUALLY TRUE
"Robinhood Chain's tokenized-stock sector is exploding"	It's counting meme trading volume inside the "tokenized stock volume" metric	The real driver is meme minting/trading, not tokenized-stock trading itself; Solana's apparent share decline reflects a diluted metric, not a shrinking business

THE CLAIM	WHY IT'S MISLEADING	WHAT'S ACTUALLY TRUE
"TVL near $1B proves capital is genuinely sticking around"	55% of that TVL is institutional stablecoin yield deposits with no connection to meme	Meme-related TVL is only about $5.2M — the institutional money and the meme money aren't the same pool
"Stock-pairing gives meme a value backstop / makes it safer"	It ignores that the wrapped asset itself is thinly liquid with broken price discovery	True tokenized stocks have only a 19.3% win rate, worse than plain meme's 51.1%; fake stock-lookalike tokens post a median loss of −52.4%
"Robinhood's own retail flow brought incremental users to the chain"	Robinhood's own app accounts for only 1–2% of daily on-chain volume at peak	The dominant traffic comes from crypto-native front-ends like GMGN/Axiom/pump.fun, not migrated traditional stock traders
"The fee decline before the subsidy expires is the stress test playing out"	The decline so far has happened while the subsidy is still active — unrelated to real gas costs	What's visible now is a natural cooldown; the real cost shock only arrives after September 29
"Arc pricing in USDC makes it the next Robinhood Chain"	It only credits the mechanism advantage while ignoring distribution and validator composition	The mechanism really is sturdier, but Arc's first-day heat has already fallen 80%, with no retail channel and no open mempool

13 What repeats next round is the "pattern," not the "vehicle"

Reason 1

The economic model doesn't run without a subsidy, and subsidies are a finite game. Pons's high-frequency trial-and-error model runs on near-zero-cost minting/trading, and that premise disappears after September 29. Unless Robinhood — or the next new chain — is willing to keep burning cash on subsidies, this exact model is hard to simply restart on the same chain; it's inherently a product of the "new-chain launch honeymoon," not a steady-state business.

Reason 2

Ported launchpads have never beaten native ones. Bags, Flap, pump.fun, and others have all tried cross-chain migration; none has ever exceeded 20% of its home chain's share, while the native-and-early teams keep winning on every new chain. Even if the next new chain replays the "gas subsidy + launchpad" playbook, the eventual winner is very unlikely to be this round's winning platform — probably a fresh face instead. Betting on a specific vehicle is high-risk; betting that the pattern itself repeats has a much better hit rate than betting on any specific token or platform.

Reason 3

Regulatory friction is escalating, not cooling off. AMC is already lawyering up, OpenAI has already gone public with its denial — this kind of dispute typically plays out as "someone sues or gets called out by a regulator, and only then does the industry get forced to add guardrails," a process that meaningfully lengthens the payoff window on every subsequent "new narrative" and makes later entrants more cautious. For traders, that likely means the window this time is shorter than last time.

Reason 4

The money sitting in TVL and the money trading meme are not the same people. Institutional stablecoin yield accounts for more than half of Robinhood Chain's TVL, and by design that capital was never earmarked for meme speculation — don't expect it to "rotate" into meme on the next wave.

Actionable signals for next time

SIGNAL	TRIGGER	HOW TO USE IT
A · New-chain subsidy window	Any new chain announces a free-gas/trading subsidy program, with a launchpad app launching or front-running around the same time	Historically, the first 3–6 weeks of a subsidy window are the golden window, after which it follows the same decay curve shown in this report; the subsidy announcement itself is the start of the countdown to enter

SIGNAL	TRIGGER	HOW TO USE IT
B · Weekend float-squeeze setup	"Small-float wrapped asset + a meme pool paired directly against it + an approaching weekend or holiday market closure" — all three at once	This is exactly the setup that produced BONER/HIMS; it can be anticipated in advance rather than chased after the fact — the moment a new token's pool pairs directly against a thin-float RWA wrapper, it's worth watching
C · Regulatory pushback = tightening signal	A public company's CEO goes public with criticism/legal threats, or an app gets pulled from an app store	Usually signals that this specific sub-sector's regulatory window is entering a tightening phase — a signal to reduce exposure, not add to it
D · Stablecoin pricing + retail entry, combined	Any launchpad or chain that combines "USDC/stablecoin-native pricing" with "a distribution channel that actually reaches retail"	Nobody has this combination yet; whoever gets there first is a strong candidate for the next PONS-scale breakout, worth tracking closely

14 Sources

- **Raw data behind this report's charts**: `api.llama.fi/v2/historicalChainTvl/Robinhood Chain`, `api.llama.fi/overview/fees/Robinhood Chain`, `api.llama.fi/summary/fees/pons-v1+pons-v2`, `robinhoodchain.blockscout.com/api/v2/stats/charts/transactions`, `api.llama.fi/v2/historicalChainTvl/Arc`, `api.llama.fi/overview/dexs/Arc`, `api.llama.fi/overview/fees/Arc`, plus dailyVolume for pump.fun/PumpSwap/LaunchLab/StonkFun/PONS (pulled 2026-09-20)
- DefiLlama: defillama.com/chain/robinhood-chain; /protocol/pons; /protocol/pump.fun; /protocol/stonkfun; /chain/arc; /protocols/Launchpad (pulled 2026-09-19)
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- CoinGecko: 2026-09-08 (launchpad revenue share), 2026-07-29 (Robinhood Chain ecosystem)
- arXiv 2602.13480 (MemeTrans, bundling/post-migration crashes); arXiv 2608.20271 (rug rates); Solidus Labs
- SolanaFloor, 2026-08-26 (Solana's 85% meme share)
- Robinhood Markets FY2025 report (released 2026-02-10, investors.robinhood.com); Wikipedia: Robinhood Markets
- Binance Alpha's 495-project long-run review (2026-09-11, independent corroboration that 9/29 is a structural checkpoint)

This piece is mechanism analysis and data reporting only — **not investment advice**. Crypto assets are extremely volatile with high liquidity risk; past performance doesn't predict future results. Make your own judgment and bear your own trading risk.

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